

Snippets

Bolt, a free calling solution in Android

If you face problems of combining free calling service with a full-fledged phone dialer app that can replace your phone's standard dialer, the Bolt claims to be a solution. The app asserts to be different from other Android free calling apps such as Viber, Skype and many more.

World's first smart earphones

Here's calling all the audiophiles out there, your life is about to change, for the better! German sound and software company BRAGI has come out with the world's first smart ear buds! The Dash is a wireless pair of completely discrete buds, which you can either connect to your smartphone or use its internal 4GB memory storage to directly load your songs.

World's slimmest smartphone

Chinese smartphone maker, Gionee, has introduced its latest offering, the Gionee Elife S5.5. At mere 0.55cm, the Gionee Elife S5.5 might just be the world's slimmest smartphone to date.

The European Space Agency has informed that this tiny-legged crawling feature-oriented robot is inspired by the biologically inspired robotic system. The robots designed by Simon Fraser School of Engineering department have their footpads covered with dry microfibers modelled on the toe hair of the gecko.

A watchdog device that can bridge any sensor or alarm to the Internet

Phantom Data Services has introduced a PhantomLink Watchdog adaptor for do-it-yourself Internet alarm monitoring and remote sensor monitoring applications. The Watchdog device is a small but powerful electronic adaptor that can bridge nearly any sensor or alarm to the Internet, providing users with instant e-mail and text message alerts.

The Watchdog's on-board micro-processor and integrated Web server makes the device a truly self-contained solution. Users can easily configure server settings, e-mail settings, trigger thresholds, trigger delays and notification intervals through the simple Web interface.

The current version of the PhantomLink Watchdog supports up to five trigger inputs (up to 15V DC), and can notify up to two e-mail or text message accounts. The device is powered by 5-15V DC power supply.

View Taj Mahal in 360-degree panorama on Google Street View

Google, in association with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), is reportedly releasing the first 360-degree online imagery of select 30 landmarks that best describe the Indian heritage sites. Now you can practically get a virtual tour of major landmarks in and around New Delhi, and also various other landmarks in the country. The Google Street View with the ASI is mapping the monuments on Google Maps and Google Cultural Institute.

The heritage sites include the iconic world monuments including Taj Mahal, Humayun's Tomb, Red Fort, Agra Fort and many more. The panoramic imagery of these 30 sites come as part of the joint initiative by the two organisations to help make a total of 100 premier heritage sites in India more approachable for everyone across the globe.

Made Nest thermostat open-source alternative

The Nest Learning Thermostat is originally an electronic, programmable and self-learning Wi-Fi-enabled thermostat that optimises heating and cooling of homes and businesses to conserve electricity.

Interestingly, the team at Spark has successfully built an open-source Nest

thermostat alternative in less than a day, proving to the world that the acclaimed lab's well-arranged assemblage of glass and aluminium is not actually that hard to copy. But what is remarkable is the fact that Spark has also open sourced the entirety of the project, making it a lot easier for other designers to carry on forward what the Spark team has done so far.

The understandably less pretty version of Nest's thermostat, the Spark prototype features just about the same array of features as the original, including sensors for temperature, humidity and motion. Further, there is also a machine-learning component which helps the device automatically adjust temperature based on user habits. All of this of course syncs with the device's Web interface, which users can access from their phones. Also remarkable is the fact that the team has built the entire prototype as well as copied the underlying software of Nest thermostat to great approximation.

Now micro-windmills to recharge your mobile phones

Recharging a mobile phone might be a cumbersome task for many, with all the crazy wires and plugs and what not! However, Dr Smitha Rao and J.C. Chiao from the University of Texas at Arlington have taken your recharging experience to an all-new level and a windy one at that.

In an example of a menacingly amazing piece of engineering, the duo have succeeded in developing micro-windmills that are just 1.8mm at the widest point, but it is only the beginning. Host hundreds of such windmills on your mobile phone and what you get is nothing short than a marvel, the entire apparatus can then charge your mobile phone on the go, claim the developers.

Intricately blending the concepts of origami and wafer-scale semiconductor devices, the developers were able to create a complex 3D structure from 2D metal pieces. In what seems to be nothing less than an engineering delight, the effort surely indicates what the future has in store for the world in terms of technology and electronics. As they say, the possibilities are indeed limitless.

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